

The Threshold Compendium

An Investigation into the Unquiet Dead, the Cursed, and the Hungry

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The ink is ash and silver. The mirror is clean.

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

Preface

I did not seek this work. It found me, as such things always do, in the space between the tide and the truth.

The waters of the Amaranthine do not give up their dead easily. I learned this as a young lieutenant, pulling bodies from the wreck of the *Mistral* – a Kahfagian cutter that had run afoul of something that had no business being in the shallows. The sailors had not drowned. I will not describe what I saw, except to say that I spent the next three years learning that the world is older and hungrier than the Admiralty's charts admit.

The attack on the cultists of Khemesh – that ill-fated expedition that claimed so many good men and women – left me broken on a beach on the Dhaharan coast. I washed ashore with salt in my lungs and a silver mirror in my hand that had not been there when I went under. When I opened my eyes, I saw not the sky, but a reflection of something that had been watching me for a very long time.

The Witness does not speak. It *shows*.

What follows is not a grimoire in the traditional sense. I have no interest in teaching the eager how to summon what should remain sealed. This is a casebook – a compendium of observations, autopsies, interrogations, and the hard-won wisdom of twenty years walking the edge between the living and the hungry.

I have organized this work by category, though I caution the reader that the categories are not clean. A ghost may become a ghoul, given enough hunger and the right soil. A demon may wear a vampire's mask. The lycanthrope's curse is kin to the plague-bearer's affliction, and both answer to Malachai's silver tongue.

The Witness demands truth. I have given it as I have found it.

Saikou Ira
Port Shed, Dhaharan Coast
The ink is ash and silver. The mirror is clean.

A Note on Patrons and Tools

I am an Invoker. I carry no Codex carved in stone, no Thiasos bound by oath. I carry *Symbols* – physical anchors to Patrons I have learned to bargain with, each for a specific purpose. Over years of walking the edge, I have found four powers that answer when I call.

The Witness My first and most constant patron. It shows me what is hidden, reveals the truth beneath the lie, and guides my investigations. When I place a silver mirror, I invoke The Witness. Its domain is revelation, memory, and the unbearable clarity of the seen.

The Traveler Lord of roads, waystations, and the space between departure and arrival. I call on The Traveler when I must escape a trap, find a path that does not appear on any map, or simply arrive before my pursuers. Its gifts are subtle – a shortcut that should not exist, a door that opens to the right alley, a helpful stranger who speaks the language of the road.

Raéyn Mistress of the sea, storms, and the tide that does not forgive. I invoke Raéyn when I am desperate – when the water rises, when the ship is sinking, when the creature from the deep has me in its grip. Her favor is fickle, but her wrath is absolute.

The Sentinel (Some call it the Sealed Gate.) Patron of thresholds, wards, and the boundary between what belongs and what must be kept out. I call on The Sentinel to exorcise spirits, to seal a room against possession, to draw the line that nothing may cross. Its power is that of the *witnessed barrier* – a line of salt blessed by a third party, a mirror facing a door, a vow spoken in the presence of two watchers.

In the chapters that follow, I will describe – when relevant – how I have used these patrons in particular cases. The rituals are not provided as instructions. They are provided as *evidence* that such bargains are possible. Whether you choose to walk the same roads is your own affair.

Contents

Preface	3
I The Unquiet Dead	9
0.1 The Spirit Taxonomy	11
0.1.1 Class I: The Echo	11
0.1.2 Class II: The Anchor	11
0.1.3 Class III: The Procession	12
0.1.4 Class IV: The Poltergeist	13
II The Hungry	15
0.2 Ghouls and the Flesh-Eaters	17
0.2.1 The Three Origins	17
0.2.2 Investigation Notes	17
III The Cursed	19
0.3 Lycanthropes	21
0.3.1 Origins and Cultural Variations	21
0.3.2 Investigation Notes	21
0.4 Vampires	21
0.4.1 The Thirteen First Vampires	22
0.4.2 Lesser Bloodlines	22
IV The Bound	23
0.5 Demons and the Infernal	25
0.5.1 The Demon's Table of Ranks	25

0.5.2	Investigation Notes	26
0.5.3	The Sentinel’s Exorcism (A Procedure in Three Mirrors)	26
0.5.4	Case Study: The Censor’s Daughter (Ecktoria, 859 AR)	28
0.5.5	The Exorcist’s Debt	29
0.5.6	Quick Reference – Exorcism Clock & Tags	29
V	The Thirteenth Chime	33
0.6	Conclusion: On the Necessity of Witness	35
VI	Appendices	37
.1	Field Procedures	39
.1.1	The Silver Test	39
.1.2	The Mirror Array (The Witness)	39
.1.3	The Traveler’s Shortcut	39
.1.4	Raéyn’s Desperation	39
.1.5	The Sentinel’s Ward (Exorcism)	39
.1.6	The Witness’s Knot	40
.1.7	The Salt Line	40
.1.8	The Ninth Measure	40
	The Three Calls: An Exorcism Deduction Mini-Game	41
.2	Creature Stat Blocks	45
.2.1	Echo (Class I Spirit)	45
.2.2	Anchor (Class II Spirit)	45
.2.3	Poltergeist (Class IV Spirit)	45
.2.4	Ghoul (Starved Anchor)	46
.2.5	Lycanthrope (Linn Sea-Wolf)	46
.2.6	Vampire (Lesser Bloodline)	46
.2.7	Demon (Class C Possessor)	46
.3	Adventure Seeds	47

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

.3.1	The Lamplighter’s Echo	47
.3.2	The Ghoul of the Sewers	48
.3.3	The Possessed Censor’s Daughter	49
Colophon		51

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Part I

The Unquiet Dead

0.1 The Spirit Taxonomy

The dead do not remain for a single reason, nor do they manifest in a single form. Over years of investigation—and, I confess, more than a few exorcisms conducted in haste—I have developed a working taxonomy of the unquiet. This is not an academic exercise. The method of laying a spirit to rest depends entirely upon *why* it remains and *how* it manifests.

0.1.1 Class I: The Echo

The Echo is not truly a spirit. It is a *recording*—a psychic imprint left by a traumatic death, repeated endlessly until the conditions that created it are addressed. Echoes do not speak, do not learn, and cannot be negotiated with. They are the scream that plays again at midnight, the footsteps that cross the same corridor at the same hour, the face that appears in the window of a house that burned a century ago.

Investigation Notes: Echoes require witness to fade. A single observer who speaks aloud the truth of the event—who names the dead and describes their end—will often break the loop. If the death was unjust, the Echo may persist until justice is done. In such cases, I have found that a public acknowledgment of the wrong, witnessed by a representative of the community, suffices where private ritual fails.

The Witness’s Technique: When I encounter an Echo, I place a small silvered mirror facing the site of the imprint. The Echo will play once into the glass. Afterward, the mirror may be shattered—each shard holds a fragment of the memory, which can be used in later investigations or ritually cleansed.

Case Study: *The Lamplighter of the Third Stack* (Aelerian Ranges, 847). A miner’s death in a gas explosion repeated every night at the same hour. The Echo was not the man’s death, but his final attempt to ring the warning bell. We placed a recording mirror at the gallery entrance, then had the mine’s foreman read the names of all who had died in that disaster into the glass. The Echo ceased. The foreman slept peacefully for the first time in thirty years.

0.1.2 Class II: The Anchor

An Anchor is a spirit bound to a specific object, location, or person by unresolved emotion—grief, rage, love, or duty. Unlike the Echo, an Anchor possesses will and memory. It can speak, bargain, and choose to manifest or withhold itself. It is, in essence, a person who has forgotten how to leave.

Variants by Cultural Tradition:

- *The Hearth-Bound* (*Vilikari, Aelaerem*): Spirits of grandparents or parents who refuse to depart until they have ensured the flourishing of their descendants. These Anchors are generally benevolent, though they may become irritable if their advice is ignored repeatedly.
- *The Duty-Bound* (*Aeler, Kahfagia*): Soldiers, watchmen, and sailors who died at their post and continue to perform their duty. I once met a lighthouse keeper who had been dead for seven years. The lamp never went out. He did not speak, but his logbook was written in a hand that was not quite attached to a wrist.

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- *The Wronged (Universally encountered)*: Victims of murder, betrayal, or accident who refuse to pass until their death is acknowledged and, where possible, avenged. These are the most dangerous Anchors, as their grief curdles into something that resembles hunger.

Investigation Notes: An Anchor cannot be exorcised by force without risk of creating a Poltergeist (Class IV). The proper method is negotiation. Determine what the spirit requires to complete its business. Offer witness—a third party who will attest to the resolution. In cases where the spirit’s demand is impossible (the murderer died decades ago, the lover has since remarried), a ritual of substitution may suffice.

The Witness’s Technique: I conduct Anchor interrogations in a room with three mirrors—one facing the spirit, one facing myself, and one placed between us to catch the reflection of the truth. The Anchor cannot lie in the space between two reflections. It may refuse to speak, but it cannot deceive.

Case Study: *The Widow of the Red Tower* (Vhasia, 852). A noblewoman’s ghost haunted her husband’s estate, refusing to pass until he confessed to poisoning her. I placed three mirrors in the great hall and asked the spirit to show me her death. The reflection did not lie. The husband confessed before dawn. The widow vanished with a smile that I still see in my dreams.

0.1.3 Class III: The Procession

A Procession is not a single spirit, but a *route*—a path that the dead walk, sometimes for centuries, between two points of significance. Processions are most common in regions where death was sudden and widespread: battlefields, plague pits, shipwreck coasts.

Characteristics:

- Processions occur on a regular schedule (nightly, monthly, on the anniversary of the disaster).
- They follow a fixed route that predates the current roads.
- The spirits within a Procession do not interact with observers. They are *marching*, not haunting.
- Interrupting a Procession—by standing in its path, attempting to speak to its members, or building over its route—provokes a violent response from the entire column.

Investigation Notes: Processions are not malevolent, but they are *inflexible*. The proper response is to observe, document, and—if the route must be altered—negotiate with the *destination*, not the dead. If a Procession marches to a specific grave or shrine, moving that terminus will often reroute the spirits.

The Traveler’s Intervention: When I need to cross where a Procession walks, I invoke The Traveler. A single pinch of road dust from a crossroads where three murders occurred, blown toward the column, causes the spirits to *step aside* for exactly the time needed to pass. I have used this technique four times. On three occasions, it worked. On the fourth, the Procession followed me for a week. I do not recommend relying on this method unless you are prepared to run.

Case Study: *The Phantom Caravan of the Saffron Pass* (Dhahara, 855). A merchant’s new road cut directly across the path of a weekly Procession. The column attacked every merchant who

attempted the crossing. I consulted with a Fhara caravaneer, who revealed that the Procession was marching from an old well to a date grove. We moved a single stone—a marker that had served as the terminus—to the side of the new road. The Procession followed the stone. The road was safe by nightfall.

0.1.4 Class IV: The Poltergeist

The Poltergeist is an Anchor that has been corrupted by rage, starvation, or the failure of negotiation. It is no longer a person—it is a *wound* that has learned to strike back. Poltergeists manifest as telekinetic force, localized environmental disturbances, and, in advanced cases, violent possession of the living.

Stages of Poltergeist Development:

Stage One (The Knock): Unexplained sounds, objects shifting slightly between observations, drafts in sealed rooms.

Stage Two (The Grasp): Objects thrown with force, doors slamming, furniture overturned. Living creatures experience nightmares, nausea, and a persistent sense of being watched.

Stage Three (The Hunger): The Poltergeist begins to feed on fear and pain. It will target specific individuals, escalating from psychological torment to physical harm. Bruises, scratches, and broken bones become common.

Stage Four (The Mask): The Poltergeist possesses a living host, using their body to commit acts of violence. Exorcism at this stage is dangerous and often fatal to the host.

Exorcism with The Sentinel: The Sentinel’s power is that of the witnessed boundary. I perform the following ritual:

1. Identify the Anchor’s original location of death or burial. This is the *root*.
2. Surround the root with a circle of salt and iron filings, blessed by a representative of the local faith. (The Sentinel does not care which faith; only that the witness is genuine.)
3. Place a silvered mirror at each cardinal point within the circle, facing outward.
4. Speak the name of the dead three times—once for acknowledgment, once for judgment, once for release.
5. Shatter the mirrors simultaneously. The Sentinel seals the break.

This ritual does not *destroy* the Poltergeist. It returns it to the state of an Anchor, at which point standard negotiation may resume.

Case Study: *The Plague House of Port Shed* (Dhaharan Coast, 858). A family of Sidhi dockworkers was being terrorized by a Poltergeist in Stage Three. The Anchor was a young woman who had died of a fever three months prior—not violently, but *alone*, her family having quarantined her. I performed The Sentinel’s containment. At the moment of release, I placed a small hand mirror in the center of the circle, reflecting her own face. The Poltergeist collapsed into a weeping Anchor. She passed into the care of a local medium. She has not returned.

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Part II

The Hungry

0.2 Ghouls and the Flesh-Eaters

The ghoul is not a single creature, but a *state*—a progression from unquiet death to active predation. I have encountered ghouls in every region of the Amaranthine, from the frozen barrows of Linn to the sun-baked crypts of Ashaan. Their origins are varied, but their behavior is remarkably consistent.

0.2.1 The Three Origins

Origin One: The Starved Anchor

An Anchor that is denied resolution for too long may begin to consume the life force of the living to sustain its own existence. These ghouls retain their intelligence and memory. They are the most dangerous, because they are the most *pitiable*.

Origin Two: The Corpse-Fed

A body buried in ground that is rich in death—a battlefield, a plague pit, a site of repeated sacrifice—may rise as a ghoul regardless of the soul’s disposition. These ghouls are *reanimated corpses*, not spirits. They have no memory of their former lives. Fire stops them. Decapitation stops them. Nothing else does.

Origin Three: The Cursed

Malachai’s touch takes many forms. The ghoul is one of her simpler curses—a gift to those who begged for immortality and received a half-life of hunger instead. These ghouls retain their intelligence, but their morality erodes over time.

0.2.2 Investigation Notes

- Ghouls cannot digest food. They consume living flesh to absorb *life essence*.
- They are vulnerable to silver, but not to the same degree as vampires or lycanthropes. A silver blade wounds them; fire destroys them.
- A ghoul that has not fed for a month will enter a state of torpor, appearing dead. It can be buried safely, but if disturbed, it will wake ravenous.
- There is no known cure for ghouls. The Well of Ichor in Zahk’Kozahn offers release, but the price is memory.

Varnek Karn’s Mercy: When I must destroy a ghoul that was once a good person, I invoke Varnek Karn. A cup of salt water—blessed by a witness who did not partake in the killing—poured over the remains after destruction ensures that the soul will not rise again. The water must be thrown by someone who never drew steel against the creature: a bystander, a family member, a priest. Varnek Karn demands that the terms of the bargain be held separate—the hand that strikes and the hand that absolves. I do not know why, but I obey.

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

Case Study: *The Dock-Rat of Port Shed* (Dhaharan Coast, 860). A young Sidhi woman was infected with ghoulishness after drinking from a cursed well. She hid her condition for two years, feeding on stray animals. When she could no longer control the hunger, she fled into the sewers. I found her—starved, weeping, clutching letters to her mother. I negotiated a feeding schedule: animal blood, provided by a local butcher in exchange for her labor as a night watchman (ghouls do not sleep, and their senses are sharp). She has not harmed a human in five years. Her mother knows. The butcher knows. I have told no one else.

Part III

The Cursed

0.3 Lycanthropes

The werewolf is a creature of paradox: a curse that feels like freedom, a transformation that erases the self, a hunger that is also a family. I have tracked lycanthropes across three continents. I have killed two. I have saved four.

0.3.1 Origins and Cultural Variations

Lycanthropy is a *spiritual infection*—a fragment of Malachai’s chained essence passed from host to host through violence, but only if the victim is in a state of profound emotional vulnerability.

Linn Sea-Wolf: Transforms into a massive seal or walrus. Solitary, melancholic, preys on ships.

Ykrul Sky-Hound: Hawk-headed hunter that transforms during the day. Hunts oath-breakers, not flesh.

Valewood Root-Walker: Transforms into a tree—rooted, immobile, but all-seeing. Guardians, not predators.

Aeler Stone-Hide: Massive, slow, nearly invulnerable. Transforms only underground. A mining hazard.

0.3.2 Investigation Notes

- Silver through the heart or brain kills them.
- Aconite (wolfsbane) poultice applied within the hour can prevent transformation.
- The full moon is not a universal trigger; transformation responds to *emotional* cycles.
- The Well of Ichor can purge lycanthropy, but the journey to Zahk’Kozahn is itself a trial.

The Witness’s Observation: Lycanthropes who remember their human lives clearly are less dangerous than those who do not. The memory of love acts as a leash on the beast.

Case Study: *The Hunters of the Scarlet Wood* (Crimson Valley, 862). A pack of feral lycanthropes with no memory. I placed a mirror at the cave entrance. As the first wolf emerged, it saw its own reflection—and for a moment, I saw recognition. That wolf was a young silk-weaver who had gone missing two years prior. I spoke her name. She stopped. We negotiated a quarantine. She now feeds on deer and speaks to her daughter through a silvered glass.

0.4 Vampires

Vampires are the eldest children of Malachai, the first to drink from the Chained Angel’s wound.

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

0.4.1 The Thirteen First Vampires

I have met three of the Thirteen. I will describe them briefly, as a warning.

Baron Quentin Asselin: The first to drink. Disillusioned, melancholic, almost gentle. Converts guests or drives them mad. *Never accept his wine.*

Sister Maris: Runs a children’s hospice. The children never leave. The Everflame has tried to destroy her hospice four times. Each time, the children defended her.

The Sparrow: Kills only the wicked, or so he claims. Cannot look at mirrors. Has saved my life twice. I suspect he is merely *bored*.

0.4.2 Lesser Bloodlines

- **Linn Draugr:** Breathe underwater, trapped by sea-salt circles.
- **Aeler Stone-Sleepers:** Drink breath, awakened by bronze bells at dawn.
- **Ykrul Bone-Eaters:** Turn to dust when killed, but rise if their name is spoken. Erase the name.
- **Vhasian Candle-Wights:** Extinguish flames through windows. A lit candle at the threshold bars them.
- **Lethai-ar Silk-Drinkers:** Feed on desire. Vulnerable to vows witnessed by a third party.

The Sentinel’s Ward: When I must enter a vampire’s lair, I invoke The Sentinel to bless the threshold of my mind. A silver mirror worn over the heart, inscribed with the sigil of the Sealed Gate, prevents the vampire’s hypnotic gaze from finding purchase. I have walked into the dens of three vampires wearing that mirror. Only once did I have to run.

Case Study: *The Court Painter of Mbaro* (Oshiira, 856). A Silk-Drinker feeding on nobles’ ambition. I confronted him in the Widow’s weigh-house. He did not flee. He wept and confessed. The Widow commuted his death sentence to indefinite confinement in a silver-lined cell. He paints the Widow’s portrait each year. She has not aged in seven years. I do not know if this is related.

Part IV

The Bound

0.5 Demons and the Infernal

I use the term *demon* with reluctance. The entities that the Church of the Everflame calls demons are not a unified species. They are a *category of convenience*—spirits that refuse to abide by the covenants of mortal society, that cannot be negotiated with in the language of debt and obligation.

A ghost, a ghoul, a lycanthrope – they are *endings* I can understand. A debt unpaid, a hunger unmet, a rage that forgot its own face. They can be pitied, sometimes even saved. But the things that come through the holes? The ones that were never alive, that owe nothing and take everything?

When I walk into a room where one of these dwells, I smell burnt clove and cold iron. My silver mirror *sweats*. The Witness goes quiet – as if it, too, is afraid of being seen.

0.5.1 The Demon’s Table of Ranks

The Church classifies by *behavior* – a practical crutch. I classify by *rank*, for every demon holds a station in the abyss, whether it remembers it or not. These are the orders I have witnessed at the threshold.

Rank I: The Whisperer (Imp)

What they leave behind: A contract written in invisible ink, a ledger with one entry more than you remember signing. They offer power, knowledge, revenge – but always through a **bargain witnessed by no one**. A contract sealed without a third party is a hole shaped like your own hand. *Counter:* A Runekeeper of Mykkiel can enforce the letter, but the price is always that the *witness* becomes the next debtor.

Rank II: The Ravager (Fury)

What they leave behind: A scorch mark on the wall in the shape of a door, a bell that rings once for every corpse. Summoned by violence or mass death, they do not speak or bargain. They **erase**. Fire and silver wound them, but the only true banishment is **overwhelming witness** – three or more souls who saw it arrive and refuse to look away. *Counter:* The moment the last witness looks down, the Ravager returns.

Rank III: The Possessor (Marquis)

What they leave behind: Nothing at first. Then, slowly, the host’s favorite food tastes like ash; their mother’s face blurs; they wake with their hands around a lover’s throat. *Counter:* An exorcism witnessed by a representative of the *host’s* faith – not the Church’s, not mine. The demon must be argued out, not forced.

Rank IV: The Parasite (Duke)

What they leave behind: An emotion that no longer belongs to you. Fear that grows teeth. Grief that walks into the next room and closes the door. Ambition that starves the body. *Counter:* Starvation – rigorous emotional discipline, sometimes requiring the host to live in a sensory deprivation cell for a moon. I have seen a man forget how to be afraid. He was not saved. He was hollowed.

Above these four ranks lie the **Princes of the Abyss**, entities of such scale that their names alone would crack the stone of this page. I have never faced one. I pray I never will.

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0.5.2 Investigation Notes

Demon summoning is forbidden in every nation that has a functioning legal system, and for good reason. Every summoning is a hole in the world.

Demon hunters require three things: silver, fire, and witness. I carry a censer that burns a compound of saltpeter, silver filings, and ironwood resin. The smoke reveals demonic possession: the host's shadow lags; the demon's shadow moves ahead.

The Weight of a Name

Every demon has a *true name*. Not the word it answers to in the abyss – that would kill the exorcist to speak. The *true name* is the **first lie it told to enter the world**.

The Whisperer's name is the clause it hid. The Ravager's name is the violence it used as a key. The Possessor's name is the moment the host said “yes” to something they should have refused. The Parasite's name is the first hunger it learned to wear as a virtue.

To learn the name, I do not summon the demon. I *audit the hole*. I place a silver mirror at the threshold where it entered, light a censer of saltpeter, silver filings, and ironwood resin, and I ask the *absence*:

“What was the first thing you borrowed that was not yours?”

The smoke reveals the answer – not in words, but in a **memory of the host's that is not the host's**. I have seen a woman weep a child's tears for a child she never bore. I have seen a man scream in a voice that was his, but cracked like a bell that had been rung too many times.

The name is always a wound. And once I know it, I owe the demon nothing – but the *host* will owe me a story they will never tell.

0.5.3 The Sentinel's Exorcism (A Procedure in Three Mirrors)

*This is the rite that never closes. Not because it fails – because it **works**, and the cost is always visible.*

You will need:

- A **silver mirror** for the host (polished in moonlight, never in sun).
- A **silver mirror** for the demon (kept wrapped in black cloth until the moment).
- A **silver mirror** for the exorcist (my own – it has a crack across the left edge. I do not remember when the crack appeared).
- A **circle** of salt, iron filings, and powdered bone (the bone must be from a person who died unafraid).

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- A **witness** – someone who loves the host, someone who fears the demon, and someone who is neutral. (Three is the minimum. I have used seven. The more witnesses, the slower the demon’s lies.)

Step 1: Draw the Circle

[ACTION: 10 MINUTES]

Walk the circle three times, counter-clockwise, sprinkling the salt-iron-bone mix. Each pass, speak the demon’s true name once. The circle will *tighten* – the air inside will feel cold; the host’s breathing will become shallow.

If the circle hisses: The demon is trying to speak through the host. Do not answer. Answering gives it a thread to pull.

Step 2: Place the Mirrors

[ACTION: 1 ACTION]

- **Host mirror** (facing the host).
- **Demon mirror** (facing the host’s eyes – the demon’s reflection will appear there, always half a second behind).
- **Exorcist mirror** (facing the demon mirror).

The three reflections must form a triangle. I have seen the mirrors crack in sequence when the demon resists. A cracked mirror does not fail – it *bites*.

[TAG: WITNESS] – The neutral witness must stand at the triangle’s apex. They do not speak. They do not blink. Their presence is the **anchor of the seen**.

Step 3: The Three Calls

[ROLL: SPIRIT + LORE vs. DV = DEMON’S RANK (4-6)]

First call:

“I name you [TRUE NAME]. You are seen. You are witnessed.”

The host convulses. The demon mirror shows a face that is not the host’s. *On a miss:* The demon speaks through the host and gains **one thread** (it can force the host to take one action on its turn).

Second call:

“I name you [TRUE NAME]. You are bound. You are contained.”

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The demon mirror *sweats*. Condensation drips down the silver. *On a partial*: The demon thrashes – mark **1 FATIGUE** on the host. *On a miss*: The demon breaks eye contact; the exorcist mirror cracks, and the demon gains **control for one exchange**.

Third call:

*“I name you [TRUE NAME]. You are **unmade**.”*

The demon mirror shatters. The shards fly inward, toward the demon’s reflection. The demon screams – not with the host’s voice, but with the **sound of a door slamming in a house with no walls**.

On a success: The demon is forced into the central mirror (the exorcist’s). The host collapses, unharmed. *On a critical success*: The demon is shattered so thoroughly that the Witness whispers the name of the person who summoned it. *On a failure*: The demon possesses the exorcist mirror. I have seen this happen once. The exorcist’s reflection smiled and walked out of the glass. It took three days to trap it again.

Step 4: Seal the Shards

[ACTION: 1 HOUR]

Each shard of the exorcist mirror must be wrapped in black cloth and **disposed of in separate bodies of water** – a river, a well, a cistern, the sea. The Sentinel seals each shard as it sinks.

“You are distributed. You are forgotten. You are no longer one.”

If any two shards are brought together, the demon can reform. I have spent years tracking down shards from exorcisms I performed decades ago. The debt never fully closes.

0.5.4 Case Study: The Censor’s Daughter (Ecktoria, 859 AR)

I did not want this case. The girl was fourteen. Her father was a Censor – a man who weighed grain and judged contracts, who had never believed in anything except the ledger.

The demon was a Possessor (Marquis). It had been with her for three years, since the night her mother died. The Inquisition had already tried to burn her twice. Both times, the fire would not light.

When I arrived, the girl was sitting in a stone cell, her hands chained to the wall. She did not look at me. The demon looked through her eyes.

“You are the one who breaks mirrors,” it said.

“I am the one who listens to the hole,” I replied.

I learned its true name by **auditing the hole** – not through the girl, but through her father’s ledgers. The demon’s name was the **interest rate** on a loan the Censor had taken to pay for his wife’s medicine.

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

The loan had been sold to a collector, who had sold it to a broker, who had died. The interest had compounded into **a debt that could never be paid**. The demon was that debt, given will.

The exorcism took six hours. Three mirrors. Seven witnesses – because the girl’s father, the Censor, refused to be one of them.

The demon fought hardest at the **second call**. It used the girl’s voice to recite the names of every person her father had bankrupted. The witnesses wept. I did not look away.

When the third call shattered the mirror, the girl screamed – not in pain, but in *relief*. Her father confessed to the loansharking. The demon’s shards were scattered into the Dolmis, the cistern of a Mykkielan chapel, a well in a village that no longer exists, and a bottle of ink I keep on my desk.

The girl survived. She works as an archivist now. She wears gloves, because her fingerprints sometimes change.

Her father died in a debtor’s cell. The interest had not been paid. It never is.

0.5.5 The Exorcist’s Debt

Every exorcism costs me something. Not fatigue – I can sleep. Not obligation – I owe the Sentinel nothing.

It costs me **witness**.

After I seal a demon, I lose a **memory** – not a skill, not a name, but a *moment* of my life. The demon’s shard takes it as toll. I do not know what I have forgotten until I try to remember.

I know I have a daughter. I cannot recall her face. I know I was a marine. I cannot recall my ship’s name. I know I have been doing this for forty years. I cannot recall why I started.

The Witness does not take these memories. The *absence* does. The hole that the demon crawled through is also the hole where my past goes.

One day I will forget my own name. That will be the last exorcism.

But not today.

0.5.6 Quick Reference – Exorcism Clock & Tags

p4cm c p8cm		
Clock Segments Triggers		
Possession Depth	8	Ticks each time the demon speaks through the host, each time a witness looks away, each time the exorcist fails a call.
Mirror Integrity	3 per mirror	Ticks on a partial or miss. At 0, that mirror shatters – demon gains control of that reflection.
p2.5cm p10cm		
Tag Effect		

— The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does. —

[WITNESS] The neutral witness adds +1 die to all Spirit+Lore rolls during the exorcism.

[MIRROR] Destroying a mirror mid-ritual (e.g., by an external attack) resets the Possession Depth clock by -2, but the demon escapes into the nearest reflection (often a PC's eye).

[SHATTER] On a critical success, the exorcist may choose to distribute the demon so thoroughly that

its true name is erased – cost: the exorcist forgets the host's name as well.

The ink is dry. The mirror is clean. The debt is never closed.

— **Saikou Ira**

Port Shed, Dhaharan Coast

The hour before dawn

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

Saikou Ira – Field Equipment

“I carry no codex. I carry witnesses.”

- **Silver Mirror (cracked on the left edge):** Used for the Mirror Array and exorcisms. The crack appeared during an exorcism in Ecktoria. Saikou does not remember which one.
- **Censer (brass, inscribed with the Sigil of the Witness):** Burns a compound of saltpeter, silver filings, and ironwood resin. The smoke reveals demonic possession and lingering Echoes.
- **Silver Coin (worn smooth):** For the Silver Test (placed on the tongue). It tastes of copper when a vampire, lycanthrope, or demon is near.
- **Bell (bronze, no clapper):** Rung to attract the attention of lesser spirits or to mark the boundary of a containment circle. The clapper was lost decades ago; the bell still tolls for Saikou alone.
- **Small Leather Pouch (salt and iron filings):** Used to draw containment circles and ward thresholds. The salt is from the Mistlands; the iron was filed from a set of manacles that once held a possessed child.
- **Journal (waterproofed with eel-fat):** Contains case notes, autopsy sketches, and the true names of three Class C demons. The pages are numbered in eights; the ninth page of each entry is left blank.
- **Thorn-Pin (silver):** Used to prick a possessed subject’s finger. A drop of blood on the pin reveals the demon’s true name as a faint whisper. The pin was a gift from a Daughter of the Cord – a debt he has not yet paid.
- **Knife (curved, no reflection):** For cutting cords, opening sealed letters, and, when necessary, cutting short an exorcism gone wrong. The blade does not show in mirrors; Saikou never uses it on the living.

Saikou carries no weapon of steel. He says steel is for soldiers. He is not a soldier. He is a witness.

I once heard of a Trow who was tricked into facing three mirrors at a crossroads at dusk. He was forced to take his own name.

The mirrors fogged. The name is no longer not his. He cannot pay the debt to himself. He is still waiting, nameless, for it to clear.

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

Part V

The Thirteenth Chime

0.6 Conclusion: On the Necessity of Witness

I have written this compendium not to frighten, but to *prepare*. The creatures I have described are not myths. They are neighbors, patients, clients, and—sometimes—the faces we see in the mirror when we are alone at midnight.

The Witness has taught me that truth is not a weapon. It is a *tool*. The truth reveals the weak point, the bargain, the memory that binds the spirit to its hunger.

I have killed. I have saved. I have wept over bodies I could not help and celebrated over curses I could not break.

The work continues.

If you are reading this, you are now a witness. The creatures I have described are real. They are hungry. They are waiting.

But so are we.

The ninth cup is not poured. The ninth bell is not rung. The threshold is held—by you, by me, by the quiet ones who tend the lamps and count the breaths and remember the names that others have forgotten.

Do not look away.

Saikou Ira
Port Shed, Dhaharan Coast
The mirror is clean. The truth is waiting.

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

Part VI

Appendices

.1 Field Procedures

For the use of investigators, exorcists, and those who walk the edge.

.1.1 The Silver Test

Carry a small silver coin. When you suspect a supernatural presence, place the coin on your tongue. If the coin tastes of copper or blood, you are in the presence of a vampire, lycanthrope, or demon. If the coin remains tasteless, the threat is spiritual (ghost, poltergeist, Anchor) rather than physical.

Do not swallow the coin.

.1.2 The Mirror Array (The Witness)

To seal a room against possession or haunting:

1. Place a silvered mirror facing each doorway.
2. Place a mirror facing each window.
3. Place a single mirror in the center of the room, facing the ceiling.

Clean the mirrors with salt water before placement. The central mirror serves as a *focus*—any spirit that attempts to enter will see its own reflection and hesitate.

.1.3 The Traveler’s Shortcut

When you need to bypass a patrol, a locked door, or a stretch of dangerous road, hold a pinch of dust from a crossroads in your left hand and whisper: *“The road that was not there, I walk it now.”* Throw the dust into the air. If The Traveler is listening, a path will open. It will not last long. Do not hesitate.

.1.4 Raéyn’s Desperation

If you are drowning or trapped beneath the waves, speak Raéyn’s name three times and touch silver to salt water. She may grant you a single breath—enough to reach the surface or to strike one blow. This favor is never forgotten. She will ask for something in return, usually on a night when the tide is wrong and the wind is silent.

.1.5 The Sentinel’s Ward (Exorcism)

To exorcise a possessing demon:

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

1. Draw a circle of salt and iron filings around the possessed. The circle must have *three* witnesses: one who loves the victim, one who fears the demon, and one who is neutral.
2. Place three mirrors: one facing the victim, one facing the demon (reflected in the victim's eyes), and one facing the exorcist.
3. Speak the demon's true name three times, learned through The Witness's revelation.
4. On the third utterance, the demon is forced into the central mirror.
5. Shatter the mirror with a silver hammer. The Sentinel seals each shard.

The demon is not destroyed. It is distributed. It cannot act, but it may be reassembled by a skilled summoner. Dispose of the shards in separate bodies of water.

.1.6 The Witness's Knot

When interviewing a suspect who may be possessed or cursed, tie a red thread around your left wrist and the suspect's right wrist. Explain that the knot binds the truth. Speak your questions clearly. The suspect cannot lie while the knot holds—but the knot will tighten if the truth is painful. Cut the knot when the interview concludes. Do not reuse the thread.

.1.7 The Salt Line

A continuous line of salt will bar most spirits and lesser cursed creatures. Use sea salt for Linn creatures, rock salt for Aeler entities, and salt blessed by any faith for general purposes. A single break—a finger's width—is enough for a determined spirit to cross.

.1.8 The Ninth Measure

When you encounter a creature or spirit that seems to have no weakness, look for what is *missing*. The ninth cup un-poured. The ninth bell un-rung. The ninth name unspoken. The ninth step uncounted. Fill the absence, and the creature will sometimes cease. *I do not know why this works. I do not ask.*

The Three Calls: An Exorcism Deduction Mini-Game

Core Concept: The demon’s true name is its *first lie*—the clause it hid, the violence it used as a key, the moment the host said “yes” to something they should have refused. Players must uncover three or more identifying *traits* through research and investigation, then speak the name during a three-stage exorcism ritual. Each confirmed trait slows the Possession Depth clock; incorrect guesses or failed rolls accelerate it. Success seals the demon; failure gives it control.

Pre-Ritual Investigation (Untimed)

Before drawing the circle, players gather clues via research, witness interviews, or forensic examination. Each discovered trait reduces the demon’s ability to lie. **Three confirmed traits** uniquely identify a demon (no two demons share the same set). Traits can also be confirmed during Step1 (Draw Circle) by spending an action on research (see Clock Triggers).

Table 1: Trait Discovery Mechanics

Action Type	Effect
Investigation (during ritual)	Roll Presence+Command vs. DV12. Success = 1 trait; Critical = 2 traits; Failure = nothing (+1 clock tick if during ritual)
Research (pre-ritual)	No time cost; reveals traits through records, interviews, observation.
Weakness Test	Attempt suspected weakness (e.g., holy water, salt circle, iron). Success confirms trait.

The Exorcism Clock: Possession Depth

Starts at 0/8 when the circle is drawn. *Only advances on specific actions—research buys time; guessing costs it.*

Resolving the Three Calls

Replace SPIRIT+Lore with **Presence+Command** rolls. Each call requires a minimum number of confirmed traits to attempt; otherwise the demon mocks the guess and the action ends immediately (clock ticks as above).

1. **First Call** – “*I name you [TRUE NAME]. You are seen. You are witnessed.*”

- *Trait check:* ≥ 1 trait?
 - **No** $\rightarrow$ +1 segment, demon mocks, **end action** (no roll).

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

Table 2: Clock Triggers & Effects

Trigger	Effect
Failed Investigation <i>during</i> ritual	+1 segment; demon whispers thr
Call attempt with < required traits (1st call needs 1, 2nd needs 2, 3rd needs 3)	+1 segment ; demon mocks the
Call attempt with correct name but insufficient traits	+1 segment; proceed to roll (trea
Call attempt with wrong name ($\geq$ required traits)	+2 segments; host convulses; 1 w
Call attempt with correct name ($\geq$ required traits)	0 segments; proceed to roll.
1 Action spent researching <i>during</i> Step1 (Draw Circle)	-1 segment; gain 1 trait (if undis
Call roll result: Miss (0 successes)	+1 segment; demon gains 1 thread
	call).
Call roll result: Partial ($0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$)	0 segments; <i>no clock advance</i> (pr

- **Yes** → Roll Presence+Command vs. DV (see table).
 - * *Success*: Proceed to Second Call.
 - * *Fail*: Demon gains 1 thread; **+1 segment** (from miss).

2. Second Call – “I name you [TRUE NAME]. You are bound. You are contained.”

- *Trait check*: ≥ 2 traits?
 - **No** → +1 segment, demon mocks, **end action**.
 - **Yes** → Roll Presence+Command vs. DV.
 - * *Success*: Proceed to Third Call.
 - * *Fail*: Host gains 1 FATIGUE; demon breaks eye contact; **+1 segment**.

3. Third Call – “I name you [TRUE NAME]. You are *unmade*.”

- *Trait check*: ≥ 3 traits (unique identification).
 - **No** → +1 segment, demon mocks, **end action**.
 - **Yes** → Roll Presence+Command vs. DV.
 - * *Success*: Demon mirror shatters; shards fly inward.
 - *Normal success*: Demon trapped in exorcist’s mirror.
 - *Critical success (all 4 traits confirmed)*: Witness whispers the summoner’s name.
 - * *Fail*: Demon possesses exorcist mirror (per core rules); **+1 segment**.

Failure States

If the Possession Depth clock reaches **8/8**:

- **Mirror Integrity Failure First**: If any mirror hits 0 Integrity (per core rules), it shatters – demon controls that reflection.
- **Clock Hits 8/8**: Demon achieves *total breakthrough*:

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

[colback=black!3,colframe=red!60!black,title=Total Breakthrough] The host’s eyes glow with the demon’s true form. Silver mirrors fog, then crack inward as if sucked into glass. The demon speaks through the host’s mouth—not in lies, but in the awful truth of its first lie. It gains control of the host’s body and one mirror’s reflection (usually the exorcist’s). The ritual fails; the demon must be re-bound.

- **Consequences:** Host remains possessed (+2 DV on future exorcism rolls); one mirror permanently shattered; each witness who looked away gains 1 Trauma.

Demon Trait Master List

13 distinct demons. Players need ≥ 3 traits to uniquely identify. Traits are discovered via pre-ritual research or during Step1 (Draw Circle).

Example Playthrough: The Censor’s Daughter (Ecktoria, 859AR)

[colback=black!3,colframe=blue!60!black,title=The Censor’s Daughter] *Pre-Ritual Investigation (Untimed):* Players checked the censor’s ledgers (found **impossible debt**), interviewed villagers (learned he paid for his wife’s medicine through a shady loan – **invisible contract**), and noted the daughter’s aversion to bread (**favourite taste like ash**). Cross-referencing loan records showed the debt was sold to a deceased collector (**debt that could never be paid**). **Three traits confirmed for Vexar (ClassA): Invisible contract, Ledger debt, Impossible debt.**

Ritual Execution:

- *Step1 (Draw Circle):* No research needed (pre-done); clock starts at 0/8.
- *Step2 (Place Mirrors):* Completed.
- *First Call:* “I name you Vexar. You are seen. You are witnessed.” (≥ 1 trait) → Success. Host convulses; demon mirror shows a ledger-clutching figure. Clock: 0/8.
- *Second Call:* “I name you Vexar. You are bound. You are contained.” (≥ 2 traits) → Success. Demon mirror sweats; condensation drips like ink. Clock: 0/8.
- *Third Call:* “I name you Vexar. You are **unmade**.” (≥ 3 traits) → Success. Demon mirror shatters; shards fly inward. Demon trapped in exorcist’s mirror.

Outcome: The girl is freed. The censor confesses to loan-sharking. Shards are dispersed to river, well, and ink bottle. The clock never ticked – preparation won the day.

— *The first lie is the key. The clock is the enemy.* —

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

Table 3: Demons & Traits (Player-Facing)

Demon	Class	Traits (Discoverable Evidence)
Vexar	A	Invisible contract; Ledger: +1 debt; Offers power via solo bargain; <i>Weak to Runekeeper enforcement</i>
Kragoth	B	Scorch-mark door; Bell: rings per corpse; Erases, doesn't speak; <i>Requires 3+ unwavering witnesses</i>
Malenka	C	Favoured food = ash; Mother's face blurs; Wakes with hands on lover's throat; <i>Requires faith-matched witness</i>
Ghoultime	D	Fear grows teeth; Grief walks into next room; Ambition starves the body; <i>Cured by sensory deprivation</i>
Nyx	A	Contract: "Sign here"; Ledger: debt doubled overnight; Promises knowledge for secrets; <i>Contract void if 3rd party witnesses</i>
Zaltar	B	Bell: tolls at midnight; Scorch: shape of open grave; Drains life from nearby plants; <i>Weak to running water</i>
Vorlagh	C	Host's laughter = hollow; Forgets own name; Sees doppelgänger in mirrors; <i>Weak to holy water of host's faith</i>
Mirelle	D	Joy turns to dread; Hope becomes obsession; Trust curdles into paranoia; <i>Cured by confessing a secret sin</i>
Ravik	A	Contract: blank page; Ledger: debt in blood, not coin; Grants visions of future wealth; <i>Contract burns if spoken aloud</i>
Skald	B	Bell: one toll = one lie; Scorch: shaped as a lying tongue; Freezes shadows in place; <i>Weak to loud, sustained noise</i>
Elara	C	Host's voice echoes; Dreams feel like memories; Finds unfamiliar objects in hand; <i>Weak to laughter</i>
Thorne	D	Sadness = physical weight; Anger = invisible fire; Greed = hunger that never fills; <i>Cured by fasting 3 days</i>
Vyre	A	Contract: sealed with tear; Ledger: debt paid in favours; Offers revenge for a whisper; <i>Weak to moonlight on silver</i>
Grim	B	— <i>The truth does not scare the vampire; the silver does.</i> — Bell: tolls for the living; Scorch: shaped as an open eye; Makes flowers bloom then rot; <i>Weak to buried iron</i>

.2 Creature Stat Blocks

For use with the Fate's Edge system. These statistics are drawn from Saikou's case files.

.2.1 Echo (Class I Spirit)

Tier:	I
Cap:	1 (non-combatant)
Traits:	Incorporeal, Repetitive, Trapped
Attacks:	None (cannot harm directly)
Complications:	Distraction (SB: 1 to create a sensory illusion), Delay (SB: 2 to cause a time loop)
Resolution:	Witness a truth about the death (DV 3) to banish permanently.
Clocks:	Echo's Loop [4] — when filled, the Echo expands its range.

.2.2 Anchor (Class II Spirit)

Tier:	II–III
Cap:	2–4
Traits:	Incorporeal, Intelligent, Bound
Attacks:	Manifestation (DV 3, Fatigue 1), Poltergeist Shove (DV 4, Harm 1)
Complications:	Bargain Required — cannot be fought; must negotiate.
Resolution:	Fulfill the Anchor's unfinished business, or perform a witnessed substitution ritual (DV 4).
Clocks:	Anchor's Patience [6] — when filled, the Anchor becomes a Poltergeist.

.2.3 Poltergeist (Class IV Spirit)

Tier:	III–IV
Cap:	3–5
Traits:	Incorporeal, Raging, Hungry
Attacks:	Telekinetic Throw (DV 3, Harm 2), Possession Attempt (DV 4, Spirit+Resist or Controlled)
Complications:	Aura of Fear (all actions Desperate within Near range), Environmental Collapse (clocks advance)
Resolution:	Containment ritual (The Sentinel) followed by negotiation with the underlying Anchor.
Clocks:	Poltergeist Escalation [8] — when filled, the spirit reaches Stage Four.

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

.2.4 Ghoul (Starved Anchor)

Tier:	II–III
Cap:	2–4
Traits:	Corporeal, Hungry, Intelligent
Attacks:	Claw (DV 2, Harm 1 + Fatigue 1), Bite (DV 3, Harm 2 + poison)
Complications:	Regeneration (ignore first 2 Harm each scene), Ravenous (must feed or frenzy)
Resolution:	Silver weapon to the heart, or fire. Negotiation possible if the ghoul is fed.
Clocks:	Hunger [6] — when filled, the ghoul attacks indiscriminately.

.2.5 Lycanthrope (Linn Sea-Wolf)

Tier:	III
Cap:	4
Traits:	Shapechanger, Amphibious, Solitary
Attacks:	Claw (DV 2, Harm 2), Drowning Grasp (DV 4, Harm 1 + Suffocation)
Complications:	Silver Vulnerability (+2 Harm from silver), Transformation Trigger (first winter storm after a kill)
Resolution:	Silver weapon to the heart or brain. Aconite poultice can prevent transformation if applied within the hour.
Clocks:	Moon’s Hunger [6] — when filled, the lycanthrope enters a frenzy.

.2.6 Vampire (Lesser Bloodline)

Tier:	III
Cap:	4
Traits:	Undead, Hypnotic Gaze, Blood Drain
Attacks:	Claw (DV 2, Harm 1), Blood Drain (DV 3, Harm 1 + 1 Fatigue to victim, heals vampire 1 Harm)
Complications:	Sunlight Vulnerability (1 Harm per round in direct sun), Invitation Required (cannot enter a home without invitation)
Resolution:	Stake through the heart (DV 5, must be wooden), decapitation, fire.
Clocks:	Thirst [6] — when filled, the vampire loses control and feeds openly.

.2.7 Demon (Class C Possessor)

Tier:	IV
Cap:	5
Traits:	Incorporeal (unless possessing), Intelligent, Malicious
Attacks (possessing):	Use host’s physical stats +2, plus fear aura (DV 3, Fear effect)
Complications:	Cannot be harmed directly while possessing; exorcism required.
Resolution:	The Sentinel’s exorcism ritual (DV 5, requires three witnesses and the demon’s true name).
Clocks:	Possession Depth [8] — when filled, the host is permanently erased.

.3 Adventure Seeds

Three scenarios drawn from Saikou Ira's unsolved cases. GMs are free to adapt them to their campaigns. Each has left a mark on me that I cannot exorcise. Perhaps you will succeed where I could not.

.3.1 The Lamplighter's Echo

Case No. 847-AE-03. Status: Unresolved.

Setup: In the Aeler mining town of *Vent-Deep*, the Echo of a lamplighter killed in a gas explosion has begun to manifest during the night shift. The Echo does not harm anyone—it simply repeats the lamplighter's final act: ringing a warning bell that no one hears. But the bell's phantom chime confuses the miners, causing them to lose count of their breaths. Two have already fallen into unseen shafts. The mine foreman, a pragmatic Iron Avenger named *Harken Veth*, wants to blast the tunnel where the lamplighter died. The lamplighter's widow, *Sanna*, begs the party to find another way.

Saikou's Observation: *"The Echo is not a haunting. It is a **question**—the same question the lamplighter asked in his last moment: "Did anyone hear me?" The widow is the only one who did. But she was not in the tunnel. She was at home, kneading bread. She heard the bell in her chest, not her ears. That is the difference between witness and witness."*

Complications:

- The Echo is not the lamplighter's death—it is his **final attempt to ring the warning bell**. The bell itself was salvaged and now hangs in the town's chapel. But the chapel is built on a threshold that the Hollow visits every ninth day.
- The lamplighter's name has been forgotten. The widow is the only one who remembers, but she is old and her memory is frayed. She fears she will forget before the next manifestation.
- The foreman has already set the charges. He is not cruel—he is exhausted. Two more accidents will close the mine and cost the town its livelihood.

Resolution Paths:

1. **Ring the Bell:** The party must retrieve the bell from the chapel on the night the Hollow walks (test Spirit+Lore to avoid its attention). Ring it during the Echo's next manifestation while the widow speaks her husband's name. The Echo will cease. *Cost:* The widow forgets the lamplighter's face. She says it is a fair trade.
2. **Blast the Tunnel:** The foreman detonates the charges. The Echo transforms into a Poltergeist (Class IV). It will haunt the mine until the party performs a full exorcism—or until it pulls the foreman into the same shaft where the lamplighter died. *Cost:* One death, at minimum.
3. **Redirect the Echo:** A risky third path. The party can ring a different bell at a different threshold, convincing the Echo that its duty is complete. Requires a [WITNESS] from the mine's entire shift crew (Presence+Command, DV 5). On success, the Echo fades. On failure, it shatters into multiple Echoes, each haunting a different tunnel.

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

Clocks:

- **Foreman's Patience [4]** — ticks each day the party delays. When filled, the foreman blasts the tunnel without them.
- **Echo's Desperation [6]** — ticks each time the Echo is ignored, each time a miner is injured. When filled, the Echo becomes a Poltergeist.
- **Widow's Memory [4]** — ticks each night she struggles to remember her husband's name. When filled, she forgets. The lamplighter's name is lost forever.

.3.2 The Ghoul of the Sewers

Case No. 852-PS-09. Status: Closed (unsatisfactory).

Setup: In Port Shed, beneath the spice warehouses, a series of missing persons reports have been linked to the sewers. The victims are always found later—alive, but *changed*. They speak of a woman who begged them not to scream, who wept while she fed. The party is hired by a Sidhi dock-master named *Old Kes*. He does not want the ghoul destroyed. He wants to know *why* she is still hungry.

The ghoul is a young woman named *Zel*. She was cursed after drinking from a well contaminated by a broken Veiled Sister's seal. She does not want to kill; she is starving. The curse has turned her into a Starved Anchor (Class II transition to Ghoul). She remembers her mother's face. She does not want to forget.

Saikou's Observation: *"I have sat with ghouls who ate their own fingers in hunger. Zel was different. She did not eat. She **collected**—torn buttons, a child's shoe, a wedding ring. She was not feeding her body. She was feeding her **memory** of being human. That is worse. That is a debt she cannot pay because the currency is no longer minted."*

Complications:

- Zel's mother, *Anja*, is still alive. She has been leaving bowls of animal blood at the sewer entrance for three months. She knows what her daughter has become. She does not care.
- Old Kes knows about Anja. He has been paying the mother to keep her quiet. He wants the party to *deal with* the ghoul—quietly, permanently, without involving the Admiralty.
- A rival smuggler, *Kaelen the Eel*, has learned of the ghoul. He plans to capture her and sell her to an Ashaani flesh-mage as a "living weapon." He has already hired a band of rat-catchers to corner her.

Resolution Paths:

1. **Kill the Ghoul:** Straightforward, but morally ambiguous. Zel will not fight back—she will weep and ask for her mother. *Cost:* Anja learns of the killing and places a **Blood Debt** on the party. Old Kes pays them, but they are haunted by her forgiveness.

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

2. **Arrange a Feeding Schedule:** Negotiate with the dock-master, the mother, and a sympathetic butcher. Zel agrees to feed on animal blood only, under witness. Requires a [PROMISE CLOCK] [4]. If broken, Zel returns to the sewers—and this time, she will not weep. *Cost:* Old Kes now owns a favor from the party. He will call it in.
3. **Attempt a Cure:** Journey to the Well of Ichor (see *Malachai, the Chained Angel*). The cure requires Zel to drink from the well and *forget her hunger*—and her mother's face. Anja must give her permission. If she does, Zel becomes human again, but hollow. *Cost:* Anja dies of grief within the year. The party gains a **String** from the Breath-less network for saving a soul, but also a **Debt** from the Veiled Sisters for "interfering with a sealed curse."

Clocks:

- **Hunger [4]** — ticks each day Zel does not feed. When filled, she attacks indiscriminately. The first target will be her mother.
- **Smuggler's Scheme [6]** — ticks each time the party delays, each time Kaelen gathers information. When filled, he captures Zel and transports her to Ashaan.
- **Mother's Patience [4]** — ticks each time the party refuses to act. When filled, Anja goes into the sewers herself to bring her daughter home.

.3.3 The Possessed Censor's Daughter

Case No. 859-EC-04. Status: Closed (with conditions).

Setup: In Ecktoria, the Censor *Fabius Valerius* is a man who weighs grain and judges contracts. He has never believed in anything except the ledger. His daughter, *Livia*, fourteen years old, has been accused of witchcraft after her body began to speak in languages she never learned—old Utaran, Pereshi courtroom cant, and once, a dialect that made the Inquisition's translator weep.

The Everflame Inquisition has arrested her. They plan to burn her at the next Triumph. Fabius refuses to speak with the party—but his ledger has a hidden page, and the page leads to a name.

Saikou's Observation: *"The demon's name was not a word. It was an **interest rate**—the compounding debt on a loan Fabius took to pay for his wife's medicine. The loan was sold to a collector, who sold it to a broker, who died. The interest compounded into a number that could never be paid. The demon was that number, given will. It had been living in his ledger for three years before it jumped to his daughter. The girl was not possessed. She was collateral."*

Complications:

- Fabius will not confess. He has spent his life enforcing contracts; he cannot admit that he broke one.
- The demon's true name is recorded in a forbidden text held in Fabius's private archive. The archive is sealed with a ward that only The Sentinel can breach. The ward is keyed to Fabius's blood.

— *The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does.* —

- The Inquisition’s schedule is fixed. The party has three days before the Triumph. The girl is held in a cell lined with silvered mirrors—the Inquisition’s crude attempt to contain the demon. The mirrors are cracking.
- A faction within the Inquisition (the *Chain-Lanterns of the Quiet Seal*) believes the girl may be innocent. They will help the party—but only if they promise to bring Fabius to justice afterward.

Resolution Paths:

1. **Expose the Censor:** The party breaks into Fabius’s archive, finds the forbidden text, and learns the demon’s true name. They present the evidence to the Inquisition. Fabius is arrested; Livia is freed. The demon is exorcised by the Chain-Lanterns (with the party’s help). *Cost:* Fabius dies in a debtor’s cell within the year. Livia never speaks again—not because she cannot, but because she has nothing left to say.
2. **Secret Exorcism:** The party performs The Sentinel’s Exorcism in secret, using three mirrors and a witness from the Quiet Seal. Requires breaking into the prison and holding the demon at bay while the ritual completes. *Cost:* The demon is sealed, but one of the witnesses (the party’s choice) forgets a significant memory—the face of a loved one, the name of a ship, the reason they started walking this road.
3. **Break the Girl Out:** The party stages a prison break, smuggling Livia to a safe house in the Vilikari marches. The demon follows. The party must now manage a fugitive arc: feeding the demon’s hunger with small lies, finding a true exorcist, and staying ahead of both the Inquisition and the Censor’s hired blades. *Cost:* Livia will never fully trust the party. She always wonders if they are saving her or using her as bait.

Clocks:

- **Inquisition’s Schedule [6]** — ticks each day. When filled, the girl is burned at the Triumph. The demon escapes into the crowd.
- **Demon’s Grip [8]** — ticks each time Livia speaks in a forgotten tongue, each time a witness looks away. When filled, the demon permanently possesses her. She becomes a vessel. Fabius will not survive the guilt.
- **Mirror Integrity [4]** — ticks each time the prison’s silvered mirrors crack. When filled, the demon walks through the reflections. The prison becomes a charnel house.

*These cases are not solved. They are **deferred**. If you succeed where I failed, write to me. I will add your name to the list of those who closed a door I could only hold ajar.*

Saikou Ira
Port Shed, Dhaharan Coast
The ink is ash. The mirror is still waiting.

— The truth does not kill the vampire; the silver does. —

Colophon

This compendium was written on the road between Dhahara and the Crimson Valley, on paper that had already served as a cargo manifest, a love letter, and a bandage. The ink is lamp-black cut with silver dust and the ash of a seal that belonged to a Censor who no longer exists.

The mirror is clean. The truth is waiting.

The ink is fresh. The road is south.